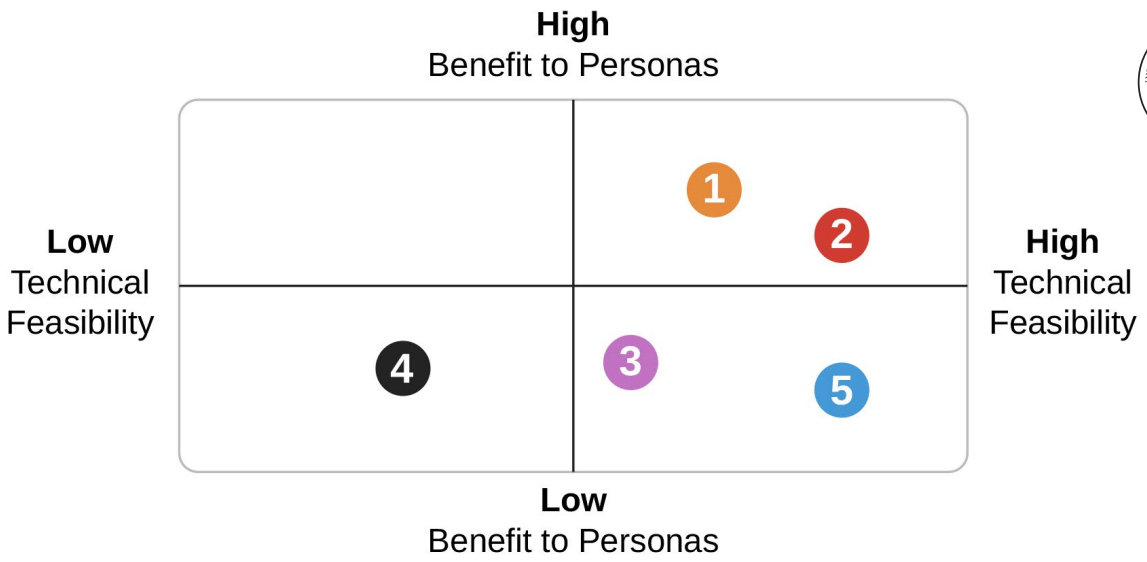

Identify Your Most Valuable Features

Prioritization Matrix

The prioritization matrix is a simple, visual way to see which features deserve your attention first. It helps you compare user benefit and technical effort so you can focus on what truly matters for your product.

When you invest in the right features, you create products people love, free your team from endless debates, and prove you can design with strategy, empathy, and results in mind.

How To Use This Template

Use this template once you've identified your features and need to figure out which ones to tackle first. The prioritization matrix works best during early planning or sprint prep, when you're deciding where to invest design and development time.

Follow the step-by-step guide to understand how to use the accompanying Excel template. This is a collaborative tool, so invite your team to join in. The conversation it sparks is just as valuable as the chart itself. You'll leave with a shared sense of focus and a clear, evidence-based roadmap that keeps everyone aligned.

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How to Use the Prioritization Matrix

A prioritization matrix helps you decide which features to implement first by comparing two key factors:

- **Technical feasibility:** How easy something is to build.
- **Benefit to your users:** How valuable it is to your personas.

The result is a simple chart that shows which features deliver the greatest impact with the least effort.

You can also use the matrix with any other two factors, such as the number of user requests for a feature and the cost to implement it. However, in this guide and the example, the focus is on the two above.

You Must Use Excel to Access the Template

This PDF guide comes with a fillable prioritization matrix template as a Microsoft Excel file (.xslx). Before you open the template, please note that **the prioritization matrix only works correctly in Microsoft Excel**.

This is because it uses Excel's advanced charting and formula features. **Therefore, the visual chart will not display properly in Google Sheets.**

To open the template, use one of the following:

- Microsoft Excel Desktop (Windows or Mac).
- Microsoft Excel for the Web, which is free to use.

Once you're set up in Excel, you're ready to start.

Choose Your Two Factors

You can use any two factors, as long as both have **positive polarity** (where higher numbers mean better). This keeps your chart quadrants intuitive: features in the top-right are high-benefit and high-feasibility.

This means that "Ease of implementation" and "Benefit to personas" are ideal as higher numbers for both mean better (easier to implement and more beneficial to personas).

However, if you replace "Ease of implementation" with "Implementation effort," which has a **negative polarity** (a higher number indicates a harder implementation), it will flip your chart and make it confusing to understand.

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How to Use the Excel Template File

The Excel file includes:

- An **example sheet** with 20 pre-filled features.
- A **blank template** for your project.

Here's how to use the template:

Step 1: Enter your data

- Add a **technical feasibility score** for each feature (e.g., 1–10).
- Add a **persona benefit score** (from your Persona-Weighted Feature Matrix or another source).
- You can use any numeric ranges; Excel automatically standardizes them.

Step 2: Let Excel normalize your data

- The workbook automatically calculates z-scores (standardized values). See the section below for more information on z-scores.
- These appear in the gray cells, so don't type into them.
- The chart updates automatically to show each feature based on feasibility (x-axis) and benefit (y-axis).

Step 3: Review the chart

Quadrant	Meaning	Example Decision
Top Right	High Benefit, High Feasibility	Prioritize Now
Top Left	High Benefit, Low Feasibility	Plan or Phase Later
Bottom Right	Low Benefit, High Feasibility	Quick Wins
Bottom Left	Low Benefit, Low Feasibility	Likely Discard

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Interpret Your Results

The prioritization matrix tells you which features are high-priority candidates, **not what you must implement immediately.**
Before you finalize your priorities, also consider:

- **Dependencies:** Some features rely on others.
- **Scheduling:** Smaller features may fit better in early sprints.
- **Technical constraints:** Platform, performance, or compliance issues.
- **Resources:** Skill sets, budgets, or available staff.
- **External dependencies:** APIs, vendors, or legal approvals.

Your matrix helps you communicate UX and user priorities clearly, but don't be surprised if technical or business realities adjust the order.

How to Adjust the Workbook

If you add or remove features, update the formula ranges for **mean** and **standard deviation** so the z-scores remain correct.

For example, in Excel's formula:

```
=(C3-C$23)/C$24
```

- **C3 =** the feature's score
- **C$23 =** mean (row fixed by $)
- **C$24 =** standard deviation (row fixed by $)

What are Z-Scores?

You don't need to know statistics to use the spreadsheet as Excel handles it automatically. However, if you're curious, here's an explanation of how Z-scores work:

- **Z-scores** show how far a number is from the average (mean), measured in standard deviations.
- This puts different scales (like 1–10 and 70–200) onto a shared basis for fair comparison.
- Most z-scores fall between **–3.0 and +3.0**.
- 0 = average
- Positive = above average
- Negative = below average

For example, if your average feasibility is **5.8** and one feature scores **6**, its z-score is about **+0.1** (slightly above average). This helps the chart compare all features accurately, regardless of the scales you use.

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Learn More. Change Your Life

Learn how to use this template to its full potential in our online course **Object-Oriented UI Design: Build Interfaces Users Love.** Sign up for it today and learn how to create effective personas from scratch if you're not already enrolled.

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- **Get excited** to transform messy requirements into smooth, user-centered solutions people instantly love. **Most designers have never even heard of object-oriented UI design, the new standard in UX.** This gives you an edge. Research shows that clear, intuitive UI **can double conversion rates**. Object-oriented UI design makes that easy.
- **Make yourself invaluable** by keeping design and development in sync. You'll discover how to avoid miscommunication, impractical proposals, and expensive redesigns, and get **recognition** as the person everyone can **trust to drive real impact with critical projects.**
- **Gain confidence and credibility** as the designer who cuts through complexity and delivers clarity. You'll master how to analyze needs, prevent feature creep, and create interfaces that **stay consistent, intuitive, and scalable.**
- **Craft your personal portfolio** with results that prove your value. You'll create career assets like conceptual models and design maps that show how you can move from requirements to **implementation-ready UIs that users love.**

Learn more about this course >

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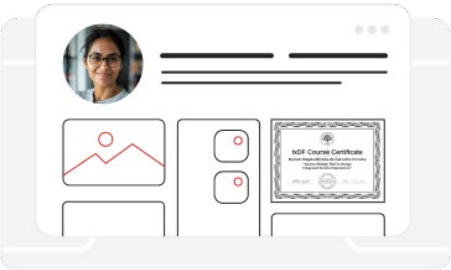

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